

Ask an AI system for the most profitable strategy and you have already decided that profitability is what matters. Ask for the most efficient organisational design and you have privileged efficiency. Ask what leading organisations are doing and you have accepted imitation as a basis for action.

The prompt does more than start a search. It encodes a criterion for success before any analysis begins. Most executives never notice they have made that choice, and that is the real risk of AI for leadership: not that the machine thinks for us, but that we stop noticing what we asked it to value.

Knowledge is not judgement

In a recent talk at the Alliance for Responsible Citizenship, Chloe Lubinski of Anthropic observed that "our moral imagination is the raw material these systems learn from — that makes up how they will understand our world."

The relationship is therefore recursive. We express our values in language, the systems learn from that language, and their outputs become part of the environment in which we form our next judgements. AI is both a product of human worldviews and an influence on them.

For executives, this changes the problem from scarcity of information to abundance. Analysis that once took teams of advisers now arrives in seconds, as ten plausible strategies instead of two. AI extends what an executive can know. It does not settle what should count.

aviewonchange
INSIGHT. CHANGE. IMPACT.
GEORGE KESSELAAR
PhD (UCT) | MBA (UCT)
www.aviewonchange.com
aviewonchange@gmail.com

A sceptic will point out that AI can reason about values too, and will offer an ethical view on request. That is true. But the executive who accepts that view has still chosen to accept it, and remains answerable for the result to a board, to employees, and to the people affected. Analysis can be delegated. Accountability cannot.

My research into executive behaviour during strategic change points the same way. Executives never meet organisational reality unmediated. They meet it through frames built from experience, norms, perceived power, and the expectations of the groups they answer to. Give two executives the same AI-generated efficiency recommendation, and one sees responsible stewardship while the other sees an unacceptable loss of employee autonomy. The information is identical. The judgement is not.

Three questions the machine cannot answer for you

The Worldview LOA framework names three things an executive brings to any AI output: a view of what is legitimate, a sense of obligation, and a capacity to act. Each gives a diagnostic question to ask before acting on a recommendation.

Legitimacy: by whose standard is this a good answer? Every recommendation is judged against a reference point, usually the norms of a reference group: investors, professional peers, an organisational culture, a national community, a faith tradition. Name the group whose approval is making this option look right. Then ask whether a different group, with an equal claim on you, would judge it differently.

Obligation: what do I owe, and to whom? The highest expected return and the leanest structure are answers to narrow questions. The executive must still decide whether return or efficiency should take precedence over other commitments the organisation has made. List who gains and who loses if you act, and which of those obligations the prompt left out.

Agency: what can I do from where I stand? Judgement only matters if it can become action. Your position enables some responses and constrains others, and it also shapes what you would prefer to be true. Ask what your power allows here, and whether your own interests are steering which recommendation you find persuasive.

The ancient scriptures have an older word for this work: discernment. In this sense, discernment is more than possessing knowledge. It is distinguishing, evaluating, and determining a fitting response. A faith-oriented executive might put the three questions this way: What is true here? What is of God, and what is not? How should I respond? The framework expresses the same evaluative movement without requiring a particular theological commitment, but the structure is identical: a reference point outside the data, against which the data is judged.

None of these questions starts from a neutral place. Even “what is actually happening here?” is answered through a frame, because the frame decides what you notice. Nor is self-awareness enough. An executive can know exactly which reference point they are using and still be using a

poor one. The test of a reference point is whether it survives exposure: to evidence, to the people affected, and to a reference group other than your own.

What my research shows

These are not abstract concerns. In my recent study of planned strategic change, executives did not simply accept or reject the formal change strategy. They evaluated each change practice against their own norms and those of their reference groups, and responded in one of three ways:

- **Suppress.** They blocked practices that conflicted with self-interest, reduced their power, or violated their own or their reference group's expectations.
- **Exploit.** They appropriated elements of the change where existing frames, power, or group norms gave them room to reshape it to their own understanding.
- **Exchange.** They engaged with practices that aligned with the expectations that mattered to them.

An AI recommendation is a change practice like any other, and will meet the same three responses. Executives will suppress outputs that threaten them, exploit outputs that suit them, and exchange with outputs that fit what their reference group already believes. The danger is that all three now arrive with the apparent authority of machine analysis, and so are harder to see.

Judgement literacy

AI literacy teaches executives to use these systems well: to test reliability, recognise bias, and build AI into decision processes. That is necessary and not sufficient. Executives also need what I call **judgement literacy**: the capacity to interrogate not only the answer a system produces, but the assumptions through which they asked for it and are now evaluating it.

The risk of neglecting this is gradual. An executive first asks AI for information, then for interpretation, then for a comparison of options, and finally for a recommendation. Each step feels like an efficiency gain. Together they hand the system the terms of the decision. The executive who is unaware of their own worldview becomes dependent on whatever evaluative assumptions are embedded in the tool.

This is not an argument against AI, or a claim that human judgement is inherently superior. A navigator is better off with accurate charts and instruments, and AI supplies both. But charts do not choose the destination, and instruments do not answer for the ship.

So before acting on the next AI recommendation, add one question to “what does the AI tell me?”: what am I using to decide what this means?

AI can increasingly tell us what is possible. Deciding what is worth doing, and answering for it, remains the executive's job.

aviewonchange
INSIGHT. CHANGE. IMPACT.
GEORGE KESSELAAR
PhD (UCT) | MBA (UCT)
www.aviewonchange.com
aviewonchange@gmail.com